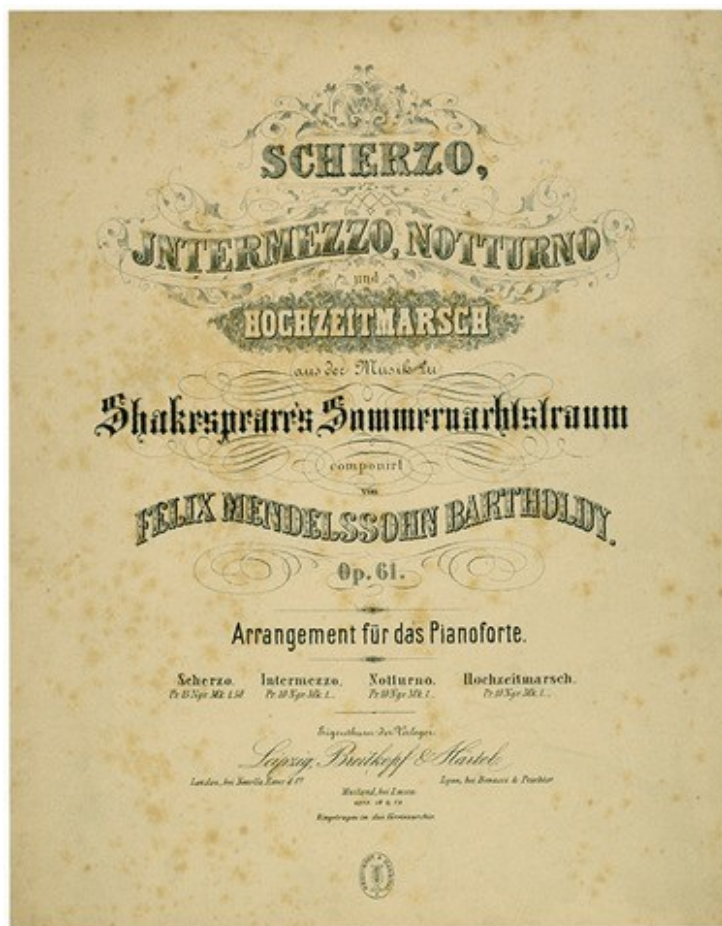


of nine, and he also excelled on the organ and violin. By his teens, he was pouring out compositions in various genres, including chamber music and symphonies; his parents even hired an orchestra so he could try out his works. At 16, he wrote his first acknowledged masterpiece, the String Octet, and at 17 the famous Overture to A Midsummer Night's Dream, which captures the fairy magic of Shakespeare's play with gossamer lightness. The history of music is full of prodigies, but not even Mozart wrote anything so memorable, original, and completely mature at this tender age.



A MIDSUMMER NIGHT'S DREAM

In 1842, 16 years after he composed his youthful Overture to A Midsummer Night's Dream, Mendelssohn wrote incidental music for the play. It includes the famous Wedding March,